

THE GHOST NEXT DOOR

Paranormal Nobodies – Episode 103

Written by

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EXT. BLACK WILLOW ROADS - NIGHT

Midnight FOG settles above the barren roads of Black Willow, almost covering the town SIGN. Headlights pierce the dark.

DIRECTOR (O.S.)
Cold sure does come in quick around
here, huh?

INT. UBER - NIGHT

The DRIVER looks wearily to her rearview mirror. MITCH VERLICE is eying the road in a drunken pessimism.

MITCH
Yeah.

DIRECTOR
October though. Everything'll still
be orange once the sun's back. You
know, Kid? Eh... you know.

She isn't convinced he knows.

EXT. VERLICE RESIDENCE - NIGHT

The car pulls into Mitch's driveway. He stumbles out of it, bidding the driver adieu. He catches a glimpse of ABIEZER MERRERO reading in the living room and goes around the back.

INT. MITCH'S BEDROOM - NIGHT

Mitch stumbles in through the window, falling over himself.

MITCH
(singing)
Break my knees / sink your teeth /
Bloody Carrie, she's so-

He goes quiet upon a realization, rolling his head to the right. To the BOX OF CARRIE'S THINGS.

EXT. MARRY'S BATH - NIGHT

Mitch, carrying the BOX of Carrie's things with GUITAR on

his back, walks up to Mary's Bath. Hell House hovers in gloom.

He pulls out her copy of Dracula from the box and hurls it into the lake. The book hits the surface with a muted splash.

Mitch's expression shifts, panic seeping in. He kicks off his shoes and takes off his guitar, diving into the water.

INT. MARY'S BATH - NIGHT

Mitch thrashes in the freezing water, clawing for the book.

IMAGES COLLIDE:

Dylan searches the same waters, her voice raw.

DYLAN

Mitch!

DOROTHY GOOD jumps into the shallows, reaching for the disassociated figure of SARAH GOOD.

DOROTHY

Mother!

Sarah wades into water, her form blending further with the dark, as Dorothy gasps for breath between paddles. TITUBA bursts through the water, gripping onto Dorothy.

EXT. MARY'S BATH - DAY (1692)

ABIGAIL WILLIAMS and BETTY PARRIS watch as Tituba pulls Dorothy to safety, then dives back in to save Sarah.

BETTY

What caused such an affliction,
Abigail? That Sarah should be so
detached from our words? Abigail!

Tituba pulls Sarah out of the water as Abigail leans into Betty, whispering.

ABIGAIL

Witchcraft.

It echoes, distorted and sinister.

EXT. MARY'S BATH - DAY

Dylan coughs up the water in her lungs, gasping for breath. A CROWD surrounds her, led by her mother JILL RODRIQUEZ and her step father MIGUEL RAMIREZ. ABIEZER MARRERO watches amongst the crowd.

JILL
Dylan!

DYLAN
Mitch.

JILL
Oh, Honey. So far all they've found
in there is a book. Dracula.

An old, odd MAN in the crowd chimes in.

MAN
Them got some strange fishes in
there. Monstrous things. Don't
y'all 'member 2016?

JILL
Would you please not be ridiculous?

MIGUEL
(whispered)
I have heard a couple crocodile
reports in the past few years.

Dylan spots a silhouette in the same window of Hell House as before. She goes towards it.

JILL
Dylan! Dylan, where are you going?!

DYLAN
Mom. Please.

Jill softens. She nods. Dylan runs towards Hell House.

Watching Dylan fade from view, Jill analyzes the dilapidated mansion. She tilts her head in consideration and then dials a number.

INT. GARDNER RESIDENCE, KITCHEN - DAY

The sounds of breakfast. HARLOW GARDNER (19, the most badass girl in Black Willow) is in the kitchen.

HARLOW
Dakota!!!! Breakfast!!!!

INT. GARDNER RESIDENCE, DAKOTA'S ROOM - DAY

DAKOTA GARDNER and SAWYER HALL shoot up in bed. They look at each other in terror.

DAKOTA
We will never speak of this. All right, Buddy?

SAWYER
All right, Pal.

They're both on the edge of laughter.

SAWYER
Wait! What time is it?

DAKOTA
Uhh. 10:45AM.

SAWYER
Shit! I wanted to audition. For Mitch's band.

DAKOTA
When's the audition?

SAWYER
11AM. I'll never make it in time. I skated here and it's like twenty minutes away.

Dakota thinks. She lights up and looks at him.

DAKOTA
Harlow!!!!

EXT. GARDNER RESIDENCE, FRONT PORCH - DAY

The front door opens before Sawyer, Harlow, and Dakota, revealing a 1970s style hippy VAN.

SAWYER

Oh. Wow.

HARLOW

It's a chill commute to school. Hop
in.

DAKOTA

(to Sawyer)

Kill it.

They zoom off.

EXT. HELL HOUSE - DAY

Dylan walks to the front door to Hell House full of
determination, then stops. Ah right. It's Hell House.

She's turning to go when a faint melody drifts from inside.
Dylan clutches her necklace, straining to hear. Mitch's
LAUGH echos through her head. She steps inside.

INT. HELL HOUSE, FOYER - DAY

The melody grows louder, unmistakable now, guiding her to
the living room.

DYLAN

Mitch?

The melody stops abruptly, alerting her.

INT. HELL HOUSE, LIVING ROOM - DAY

Dylan thrusts open the door, revealing Mitch. He's sitting
on a couch, clutching his guitar. Carrie's box of
possessions sits at his bare feet. Dylan charges, hugging
him.

DYLAN

Are you insane? Never do that
again! Do you know how worried
everyone is?

MITCH

What?

Dylan shows him the crowd that's formed around his shoes.

MITCH

Oh shit.

He almost laughs, then turns to Dylan. She's never looked at him like this.

MITCH

You really hurt me last night.

He sits on the couch. Dylan joins him.

DYLAN

You're a peanut pumpkin. I get it now. You have so much sweetness that it turns into a shell that's hard and ugly.

MITCH

Is this supposed to be an apology?

Dylan shrugs, eyes soft.

MITCH

...Deer. You'd be a deer.

Dylan smiles.

MITCH

I'm sorry for embarrassing you.

DYLAN

You don't embarrass me. I was just anxious at the party.

MITCH

Oh yes! Your phone call. That's right. What happened?

The fear in Dylan returns. She hears an eerie noise.

DYLAN

What is that?

MITCH

The spirit box!

Mitch pulls out a SPIRIT BOX, excited. He points it around.

MITCH

Shit! Dylan! You did it! You're in Hell House.

He laughs wildly, proud of her.

DYLAN

(MORE)

DYLAN (CONT'D)

Mitch we need to leave. You have...
band auditions. Everyone's waiting.

MITCH

What? Veda can handle that.

Dylan catches sight of a mirror, transfixed by it.

DYLAN

Mitch... MITCH.

Dylan points to the mirror. A shadowy figure (Raymond) fades into it's reflection as the spirit box goes crazy. Mitch stands in utter shock, frozen.

DYLAN

We have to go!

He doesn't budge.

DYLAN

Now!

She bolts. Mitch grabs his guitar, flying out after her.

EXT. HELL HOUSE - DAY

The group by Mary's Bath is on their way towards Hell House when Dylan and Mitch burst out of it, gasping for breath. Mitch, elated, laughs like a lunatic.

MITCH

You! Are you OK?

She nods, I guess so. He PICKS Dylan up, SPINNING her around.

MITCH

You little ghost magnet you!

Mitch KISSES HER ON THE NOSE like it's nothing. From Dylan's point of view, everything SLOWS and SWIRLS in on her.

MITCH

Meet me at your place. I'll grab
the tools!

The crowd charges Mitch, but he breaks through their prying.

MITCH

(MORE)

MITCH (CONT'D)
Aye! I'm alive! Sorry for the
scare. Gotta bounce though! HA!
We're gonna change the fucking
world.

He keeps running. Dylan's hand hovers over her nose.

DYLAN
...Bet.

TITLE CARD: EPISODE 3, THE GHOST NEXT DOOR.

INT. VERLICE RESIDENCE, GARAGE - DAY

The garage buzzes with worried MUSICIANS. Veda is pacing.
Mitch rushes in, thoughtless to everyone. She exhales deeply
before her eyes narrow.

Veda
WHAT THE ACTUAL FUCK.

He heads straight towards the ghost hunting equipment.

MITCH
Can't talk. Cracking the ether.

VEDA
What?

MITCH
Making friends with a GHOST.
Helloo.

VEDA
And the band?

MITCH
You pick. Look at these guys.
They're stunning. What a pull.

They are not stunning, nor what a pull.

VEDA
They all suck.

She cocks her neck at their offended faces. The musicians
pack up. Mitch raises his eyebrows: yikes. Just then,

Harlow's van rolls to a stop and Sawyer jumps out. Everyone looks at him for half a second and then forgets all about it.

VEDA
So that's it? Screw the band then?

MITCH
(to Veda)
I'll find someone.

SAWYER
Am I late?

MUSICIAN
It's a shit show in here, Man. I'd just dip if I were you.

Harlow steps forward. She plugs in a guitar, hands it to him.

HARLOW
Fuck em up, Little Guy.

Sawyer nods, uncomfortable but encouraged.

He PLAYS, filling the whole place with an electric energy. Mitch finally TURNS around out of complete awe.

Sawyer's final chord vibrates through the silence.

MITCH
(to Veda)
We good?

VEDA
Just make him look less annoying.

INT. KLAYPOOL RESIDENCE, DYLAN'S BEDROOM - DAY

Dylan lays in bed, staring at the ceiling. She pulls out her phone for social media. A TAROT READER pops up on her screen.

TAROT READER
Ooooooh, girl! I don't know who you be thinking about, but you know you be lying to yourself about it
HAHAH-

Dylan shuts off the phone, resumes staring at the ceiling.

INT. KLAYPOOL RESIDENCE, LIVING ROOM - DAY

Dylan reads in the living room while Jill works. The portrait of a mother and daughter bonded by both indifference and obsession. Dylan reaches for a BOWL of Halloween candy.

JILL
Eh! Not before dinner.

Dylan begrudgingly obeys. They return to silence.

JILL
Mitch all right?

DYLAN
What?

JILL
I asked if Mitch is OK. Some kiss
he gave you.

Dylan's eyes bulge. Jill gets a call.

JILL
Hello? Oh, yes! Ronald. Hi, there.
I'm so happy to hear back from you.

Dylan mouths, "It was on the nose! We're just friends," to Jill, who responds with a lifted finger: hold on I'm busy.

JILL
Yes. It's a live podcast, live
audience of professionals in the
field. No randoms off the street,
no. Not in this town.

Dylan gives Jill a look.

JILL
Yeah! It's on the existence, or
rather lack thereof, paranormal
activity.

Dylan's attention increases.

JILL
Well, yeah. It is a flawless
location if you don't mind my
saying. Very fun for the season.

The doorbell rings. As Dylan gets up to answer it, Jill mouths, "ask him to dinner." Dylan mouths back "no!"

JILL
Yes! Let's talk dates.

INT. KLAYPOOL RESIDENCE, FRONT DOOR - DAY

Dylan opens the front door to find Mitch with a bag of ghost hunting equipment and Dylan's TEST in his hand.

DYLAN
Mitch. Um. Hello. Please. Come in.

As he enters, Dylan steals a glance of herself in a mirror.

INT. KLAYPOOL RESIDENCE, KITCHEN - DAY

Mitch sits at the dining table, grading Dylan's test while she watches from the floor. Unnoticed, Dylan observes the details of his image down to the pulse of his neck. She watches his fingers tap.

MITCH
Dylan? You got a 100%!

She snaps out of it.

DYLAN
What? Oh! Yay!

MITCH
Which means we can go back to Hell House.

Dylan shrinks into herself.

MITCH
Hey. Hey. How dare you think?

She looks at him, frowning.

MITCH
You know where I got that from? A Little Princess.

DYLAN
I love A Little Princess.

MITCH
I know you do. Now, come on. Here.
(MORE)

MITCH (CONT'D)

Have a baguette.

Gawking at Mitch, Dylan takes the baguette.

DYLAN

Thank you-

She bites the baguette and spits it out.

DYLAN

Eck! How old is this?

Mitch grabs the letter from Ronald Hodge and reads it.

MITCH

Detective Miguel Ramirez, I can't
thank you enough for your property
recommendation on that house next
door to yours...

Mitch looks at Dylan. She snatches the card, reading.

DYLAN

It's a spooky place all right, but
would feel more like home with the
right gutting and renovation.

EXT. HELL HOUSE - DAY

Jill walks up to Hell House.

DYLAN (V.O.)

At least that's what the new Mrs
says. She's looking forward to
breaking walls by mid November and
being neighbors. Says our daughters
get along.

Jill knocks on the front door.

DYLAN (V.O.)

Anyway, thought you'd like to share
in the celebration. We closed
yesterday.

RONALD HODGE (60s) and CHARLOTTE HODGE (30s) open the door.

HODGE

(MORE)

HODGE (CONT'D)

Howdy!

Spoken simultaneously with:

CHARLOTTE

Howdy!

CHARLOTTE

Thank you so much for the rec.
Really. Awful to hear what happened
this morning though. We've got this
going up right away.

She dangles a massive LOCK by her pointer finger.

JILL

I'm glad to hear it. And we're good
to go on hosting my podcast here?

HODGE

Set up anywhere you'd like.

They let her in. The real estate sign outside says SOLD.

MITCH (V.O.)

Your mom just went inside.

INT. KLAYPOOL RESIDENCE, SILO ATTIC - DAY

Mitch stands at the window of the silo attic, watching Jill
through the windows of Hell House with a pair of BINOCULARS.
Dylan, who was pacing, rushes to his side.

DYLAN

What? Let me see.

MITCH

Hold on. I can read lips.

DYLAN

Let me see!

Mitch flicks her away.

MITCH

SHUSH.

Dylan crosses her arms. Restless and pensive, she considers
the ceiling mural.

CANDICE (V.O.)
(echoed)
Not alone.

Dylan tenses, her eyes darting. She barely speaks a whisper.

DYLAN
Grandma?

MITCH
Your mom's talking to Chief Hodge.

Dylan's full focus returns to Mitch. Down at Hell House, Jill says "this would be a great place to set up," to Hodge.

MITCH
She says... This whip buried
Priscilla Boot. Do we know anything
about a Priscilla Boot?

Dylan facepalms.

JILL (V.O.)
We're... so glad you could join us
for dinner, Mitch.

INT. KLAYPOOL RESIDENCE, KITCHEN - NIGHT

Mitch sits at the dinner table with Jill, Miguel, and Dylan, embodying Edward Scissorhands.

MITCH
Thank you for having me.

JILL
(to Miguel)
Dear, I was out visiting Ron next
door and guess what! We're good to
go with the podcast!

Dylan and Mitch perk up, locking eyes.

MIGUEL
Oh! Honey, that's amazing!

DYLAN
You're doing a podcast next door?

JILL
(MORE)

JILL (CONT'D)

On Wednesday to promote my new book
and I expect you to be there.

DYLAN

And this is the book that happen to
be about-

JILL

Yes which is exactly why you need
to be there. Mitch! You can come
too if you'd like.

MITCH

Oh. Yeah!

When Jill and Miguel lower their heads to eat, Mitch tries
to pantomime "we can ghost hunt during the podcast" to
Dylan, but it just comes across as sexual. Mitch realizes,
changing gestures. Dylan finally nods, still concerned.

They eat to the score of forks hitting plates. Mitch almost
chokes on a spaghetti noodle. He coughs and coughs.

JILL

Oh my gosh. Are you all right?

Mitch nods, clearly not all right. He has a sip of water.

MITCH

(weak)
Wrong pipe.

They give him an understanding nod. Silence resumes.

MITCH

What's it-

Spoken simultaneously with:

MIGUEL

So, Mitch-

MITCH

Sorry. You go ahead.

MIGUEL

Are you and Dylan dating now?

Dylan almost spits out her drink.

DYLAN

We're just friends.

MITCH

(MORE)

MITCH (CONT'D)

Dylan is way out of my league
anyway so...

Dylan tenses, looking at him, then turns away fast.

JILL

You know...It's really interesting,
Mitch because... Well, Dylan has a
very strong distaste for anything
scary or dark natured.

DYLAN

Mom...

JILL

What? I just find it fascinating
how, despite that, the two of you
have managed to become so close.

DYLAN

Mom!

MITCH

I guess it just goes to show that
there's more to people than their
appearance or job.

Jill fakes a smile.

MITCH

Plus, I uh, I know Dylan's not a
fan. You should see her over at the
graveyard. She stands so stiff that
no ghost would want to come near.

JILL

Well... it's not as though the way
she stands would make much of a
difference.

MITCH

Why's that?

JILL

Because ghosts aren't real, of
course.

DYLAN

That's not true.

JILL

Oh, Dylan. Give me a break.

MITCH

(MORE)

MITCH (CONT'D)

Really? You don't believe in them even a little?

JILL

In no capacity. I was a professor of neuroscience at Vanderton University before our move. Paranormal experiences are very similar to the delusional insanity some people encounter during "religious experiences." It's... it's actually what the podcast is on.

DYLAN

Those people are neither delusional nor insane.

JILL

Dylan, I'm speaking. You should hear this. With schizophrenia affecting nearly one percent of the population, we have fifty-one million patients out there telling absurd ghost claims. Do I think those people don't see things? Do I think they don't feel things? Of course not, but that doesn't make their claims objectively real. They're sick is all. With proper treatment, even the worst of them may heal.

DYLAN

Not being able to see something does not make it any less real... And who are you to decide what's real and what's fake? Have you ever seen bacteria? No, but you know it's real. Why is this any different?

JILL

I have under a microscope.

DYLAN

Ok. Well, there are tools to detect ghosts too.

JILL

It's a pseudoscience, Honey. Have you heard of Dr. Franklin Crowe?

DYLAN

(MORE)

DYLAN (CONT'D)

Then what would it take?! No, seriously. What would it take for you to, just once, believe in something you didn't learn from a textbook? To listen to your heart, to your gut. To believe in people instead of prescribing them until they're just as numb as...

JILL

Honey. I know this is hard for you to understand when you still have so much to learn-

DYLAN

You've gotta be kidding me.

Dylan storms out of the house.

JILL

Dylan! Dylan Cassandra Klaypool!

Dylan slams the front door. Miguel grabs Jill's hand. Mitch almost smirks.

MITCH

(quietly)

We're all a little haunted, aren't we.

JILL

What did you just say?

MITCH

Nothing. Thank you for the lovely meal. I'll just-

MIGUEL

Yeah.

Mitch looks at Miguel, who gives him a sympathetic nod. Mitch leaves. Jill puts her hands in her head.

EXT. YOUNG DYLAN RESIDENCE - NIGHT (FLASHBACK)

Jill walks into the night air, wrapping herself in the cardigan. It's unbearably quiet.

JILL

(MORE)

JILL (CONT'D)

Nathan?

She steps forward and something CRINKLES: SALT.

Something SCURRIES along the side of the house. She grabs a gardening SHOVEL.

Jill walks down the steps of her front porch, shovel poised for defense. She approaches in a heavy breath, ready to defend herself from whatever is on the other side.

Jill spins, full of offense, only for her eyes to land on NATHAN KLAYPOOL. He's holding a huge CAN of salt, surrounding the house in a circle of it. He starts to HUM.

JILL

Nathan?

NATHAN

Jill! Is Dylan all right?

JILL

Yes. Of course. What are you doing?

NATHAN

It's something in the... sodium chloride, you see. It'll rid us of all the evil spirits.

JILL

OK... Sweetheart? I'm going to need you to come back to bed now. Can you come back to bed with me?

She touches him gently and he flinches away.

NATHAN

I won't go to bed. No, no. I can't go to bed.

JILL

But why-

A FLUX RESPONSE DEVICE begins to blink.

NATHAN

Your mother gave this to me. A flux response device. It detects paranormal activity.

He looks around the woods as if he heard something.

JILL

(MORE)

JILL (CONT'D)

You can't possibly believe a word
out of my mother's mouth. Nathan.

Nathan shuts his eyes tightly, covering his ears in pain.

JILL

Nathan!

NATHAN

It's haunted in there, Jill! Open
your eyes. You think I'm just going
to, to what, to sleep? While our
little girl is-

JILL

Listen to me! Nothing is haunted!
We're all fine! Everything is fine!

Nathan laughs and then cries.

JILL

Sweetheart...

NATHAN

We're all a little haunted. Aren't
we.

Something SOUNDS from the bushes, they both turn their
heads. It's YOUNG DYLAN (6), watching. She hurries into the
bushes.

NATHAN

Dylan!

Nathan runs after her, followed closely by Jill. They
gradually camouflage into the nighttime foliage-

EXT. KLAYPOOL RESIDENCE, BENCH - NIGHT

-blending into Mitch as he makes his way through the trees.

MITCH

Dylan! Dylan?

DYLAN (O.S.)

Over here.

Mitch looks behind bushes. Dylan is sitting fairylike on a
bench. He climbs through and joins her.

MITCH

(MORE)

MITCH (CONT'D)
I'm sorry for infiltrating your
hiding space.

DYLAN
It's one of many.

Dylan stares off.

MITCH
Are you OK? ...You remind me of the
snow.

She looks at him cautiously. How so?

MITCH
You're cold, but it makes you
lighter. Everything about you lands
lighter and somehow, after a while,
when it happens no one knows,
everything's covered in you.

DYLAN
...Sounds dangerous.

MITCH
Ah. A little bit of heat and-

DYLAN
I melt.

They lock eyes. Tension!!!!

MITCH
Shit! Did I KISS you?

DYLAN
What?

MITCH
Back at Hell House! I kissed you,
didn't I? Oh my...

DYLAN
I mean, just... on the nose.

He buries his face in his hands.

MITCH
What? Were you just not going to
say anything?

DYLAN
(MORE)

DYLAN (CONT'D)
I mean I was quite content with
pretending it never happened so...

MITCH
(mortified)
Dylan... Dylan!

He hugs her, pausing along the way to check her comfort.

MITCH
I apologize. You made it very clear
you don't feel that way towards me
and I should have been more
considerate.

DYLAN
Oh that's, you know, it's, it's all
right. Really.

MITCH
(joking)
You don't have feelings for me now,
do you?

DYLAN
What... no.

Mitch stares at her, blank-faced. Intense. Dark. She tries
to avoid the eye contact.

DYLAN
We can't only ghost hunt during the
podcast. The spirit might be shy.
How are we gonna get into Hell
House before Wednesday?

He grins.

INT. KLAYPOOL RESIDENCE, KITCHEN - NIGHT

The only sound is Dylan helping Jill do the dishes.

DYLAN
Thanks for making dinner, Mom. It
was really good... Did you use
rosemary on the salmon? I feel like
I could taste rosemary.

Jill stops. She turns to Dylan, hand on her hip.

DYLAN
(MORE)

DYLAN (CONT'D)

Can I go out tonight?

Jill shakes her head in disbelief, returns to cleaning.

DYLAN

I thought you'd be happy I'm finally making friends.

JILL

I am! I'm just...

DYLAN

What? What, is it Mitch? You're okay with Carrie, but not Mitch?

JILL

I'm only saying I know his type. And I'm worried-

DYLAN

About what? That you'll accuse him of attacking me in the middle of the night because he reminds you of my dad?

Jill breaks a plate. She looks into the draining sink water.

JILL

Nathan Klaypool is the most horrible, sick human being I have ever had the displeasure of knowing. He may be your father, but he sure as hell is not your dad. Do you understand?

Dylan gives Jill a glare that could kill. Then, she calms.

DYLAN

I understand. May I please be excused?

JILL

Sure.

Dylan goes upstairs with poise.

INT. KLAYPOOL RESIDENCE, DYLAN'S BEDROOM - NIGHT

With a strained composure, Dylan opens and closes her door... then gets to work in a RAGE. She stuffs things in her cross body bag: SAGE, CRYSTALS, a VIDEO CAM.

She zips up a BLACK HOODIE and clips the EVP RECORDER to her

jeans, puts the earbuds in. She slips on a NEWSBOY HAT and tips the lid. Ready.

EXT. KLAYPOOL RESIDENCE - NIGHT

From outside, Mitch watches Dylan sneak out of her house. He notices something different about her energy. Vindictive.

DYLAN
What?

MITCH
(smirking)
Nothing.

EXT. BLACK WILLOW WOODS - NIGHT

Dylan and Mitch walk uphill through a layer of fog, Mitch trying to keep up with her newfound determination. He looks around, sensing something, and spots boot prints in the dirt.

MITCH
Someone was just here.

DYLAN
Mary's Bath is right behind us.
Tons of people were just here.

MITCH
But it's rained since then. These
boot marks are fresh. Dylan.

He runs to catch up with her.

MITCH
Something doesn't feel right. I
feel-

He catches up with her, coming face to face with Hell House. It's boarded up with a large LOCK on the front door and a NO TRESPASSING sign.

MITCH
...unwelcomed.

DYLAN
(MORE)

DYLAN (CONT'D)

Yeah?

Dylan searches the front yard until she finds a large rock.

MITCH

What are you doing?

DYLAN

Well I bet the ghost who lives here
didn't appreciate the intrusion of
those sorry asses who-

DYLAN

(throwing)

-BOUGHT THIS PLACE.

MITCH

Dylan!

Dylan CHUCKS the rock at a window, SHATTERING IT.

INT. POLICE STATION - NIGHT

Cameras FLASH. Dylan looks terrified in her mugshot. Mitch
is smiling from ear to ear in his.

INT. JILL'S CAR - NIGHT

Jill drives Dylan home in deafening silence.

DYLAN

Thanks for picking me up from jail.

INT. KLAYPOOL RESIDENCE, FOYER - NIGHT

Jill and Dylan enter the house, agonizingly quiet.

JILL

Is it sex?

DYLAN

Mom!

JILL

Drugs? A desire to feel more alive?

DYLAN

(MORE)

DYLAN (CONT'D)
No! None of that.

JILL
What is it then? Tell me!

DYLAN
WE'RE GHOST HUNTING...

Jill looks like she's fighting back tears.

DYLAN
It's good for me to face my fears.
Don't you think that's true?

Jill looks at her. It is true.

DYLAN
If they are real, I want to... try
and find grandma.

JILL
What? Oh, Dylan. We don't even know
if she's dead.

DYLAN
And I hope she's not. But maybe one
of the ghosts might know something
about what happened. And, and think
of it this way. If ghosts really
are fake, I'll have no doubts about
it by the time I finish all this
hunting stuff. And, I don't know,
maybe I'll be better because of it.

JILL
...No. I'm sorry, Dylan. I can't
condone this. Not ghost hunting.
Give me your phone.

Dylan coughs up her PHONE.

JILL
I can see how your social life here
is expanding. So, while I am taking
this phone from you for the time
being, you are not grounded from
going out. BUT! ...I never want to
see you with Mitch again.

Dylan freezes. Jill gives her a hug, then heads upstairs.

JILL
(MORE)

JILL (CONT'D)
It's true. He's too much like your
father.

INT. KLAYPOOL RESIDENCE, DYLAN'S BEDROOM - NIGHT

A tearstained Dylan lays in bed.

MIGUEL (O.S.)
You didn't ground her?!

Dylan looks towards the noise.

INT. KLAYPOOL RESIDENCE, JILL'S ROOM - NIGHT (CONTINUOUS)

Jill shushes Miguel, gesturing towards Dylan's bedroom.

MIGUEL
(quieter)
The girl was arrested. She broke
into my boss's house!

JILL
And I'm taking care of it.

MIGUEL
I could get fired for this.

JILL
But you won't. In fact, thank
goodness you're friends with Ronald
because Dylan wouldn't have gotten
off half as easy otherwise.

MIGUEL
That didn't prevent the \$10,000
bail.

JILL
She got off on a bond.

MIGUEL
And when she's found guilty?

JILL
You and I both know she'll get
community service at worst.

MIGUEL
(MORE)

MIGUEL (CONT'D)

With the boy, no doubt. The one you forbade her from seeing after I specifically said-

JILL

I had no choice! Am I really expected to allow that boy back into my house-

MIGUEL

Our house.

JILL

Of course.

MIGUEL

No. Not of course. I'm hearing a lot of me, my, and I in this conversation, but I have been that little girl's dad for ten years now and I get to make decisions too!

JILL

Fine! You're failing! Happy now?! ...I'm sorry. You're right.

MIGUEL

Thank you. And we don't have to ground her. Just... make her get a job until what the bail would have been is paid off. As a lesson.

JILL

A job where?

INT. KLAYPOOL RESIDENCE, HALLWAY - NIGHT (CONTINUOUS)

Dylan leans on Jill's bedroom door, listening. Where?!

EXT. POLICE STATION - DAY

A "VOTE MORGAN HALL FOR MAYOR... AGAIN!" sign wobbles as a car speeds past the police station.

DYLAN (V.O.)

I'm really sorry, Chief Hodge.

INT. POLICE STATION, HODGE'S OFFICE - DAY

Dylan and Miguel stand before the desk of Ronald Hodge.

DYLAN

Thank you for letting me work here.

HODGE

Don't worry a thing, Darling.
Window was already gonna go so you
saved a step far as I'm concerned.
Bail'll be paid off in no time.

MIGUEL

They were ghost hunting. Can you
believe that?

HODGE

You don't say. Well hey maybe I'll
hire you down the line if I feel
anything off in there. You know, I
got a step-daughter Dylan's age.
Two of us are aboutta grab a bite.
What do you say we make it four?

INT. DINER - DAY

Dylan squirts ketchup onto her burger. While taking a bite,
she clocks the restaurant's public phone.

Hodge and Miguel's attention shifts. Entering the diner
is... LEXIE WILSON.

HODGE

Well hello, Sweet Pea. Aren't we
glad you could make it. This here's
Dylan, the one I told you about.

LEXIE

(looking at Dylan)
We've met.

Dylan gulps.

INT. VERLICE RESIDENCE, LIVING ROOM - DAY

Abiezer sits on his rocking chair with a book, sipping tea.
Mitch is beside him, also reading. He puts the book down.

MITCH

Abi. Abi, are you really not gonna ground me?

ABIEZER

Hm?

MITCH

For getting arrested?

Abi shrugs.

ABIEZER

Do you want to be grounded?

The house phone rings.

MITCH

I'll get it.

Mitch springs up and grabs the phone.

MITCH

Verlice residence and Black Willow boneyard. Mitch speaking.

INT. DINER, HOSTESS AREA - DAY

Dylan cowers beside the restaurant phone, keeping an eye out.

DYLAN

It's me. How are things over there?

MITCH

Oh, you know...

INT. VERLICE RESIDENCE, LIVING ROOM - DAY

Abiezer turns a page in his book and gets a paper cut. He flicks his hand and kisses it.

MITCH

Real rough.

ABIEZER

That Dylan?

MITCH

(MORE)

MITCH (CONT'D)

Yes.

ABIEZER

Tell her I say hello.

INT. DINER, HOSTESS AREA - DAY

Dylan rolls her eyes.

MITCH

Abi says hello. How are you?

DYLAN

Well I'm not grounded, but my phone was taken for approximately forever and I'm especially forbidden from seeing you, which is a ruling we'll have to overturn if we're to ghost hunt during my mom's podcast.

MITCH

Yes, Ma'am. What's the plan?

INT. HALL RESIDENCE, SAWYER'S BEDROOM - DAY

- Dark brown-black hair dye plops into a bowl. Sawyer dawns gloves. Slaps a glob of it onto Mitch's hair.

- Mitch's Spider earrings clink into a bowl.

- Mitch, hair dye still in and styled as a mohawk, has an apple in his mouth as he ices Sawyer's ear.

MITCH

You ready?

Mitch raises the needle.

INT. HALL RESIDENCE, PARKER'S ROOM - DAY

Parker is lifting weights.

SAWYER (O.S.)

SHIT!!!!

He drops them and they hit his foot. He hops around in pain.

INT. HALL RESIDENCE, SAWYER'S BEDROOM - DAY

Parker barges into Sawyer's room.

PARKER
DUDE! SO YOU MIND-

Mitch and Sawyer are on the bed, doing each other's nails.
...Parker closes the door slowly.

SAWYER
I'll hear about that later.

MITCH
Why?

He gives Mitch a look, then continues removing his nail polish. Mitch raises both eyebrows.

MITCH
Band PR. That plus your new look
and we are golden.

They paint each other's nails in intervals, Sawyer cleaning one of Mitch's nails then Mitch painting one of Sawyer's.

SAWYER
Why am I dulling you down then?

MITCH
So Dylan's mom will like me.

SAWYER
Are you and Dylan, like, a thing
now?

MITCH
Nah. Nah. Oh! I kissed her though!

SAWYER
What?!

MITCH
(nodding)
On accident. Eh. Kind of. But I
don't think I'm her type.

Mitch looks at his bare nails, considering.

SAWYER
(MORE)

SAWYER (CONT'D)

Do you like her, or?

MITCH

...Maybe I would. If we met at another time.

Sawyer nods, thinking. Mitch lifts Sawyer's painted hand.

MITCH

You ready to switch fits?

EXT. HELL HOUSE - NIGHT

A black car pulls up, the back door opens. A cane pops out, followed by feet and scruffy fingers. The fingers pick up a pinch of dirt, testing the texture. They raise to reveal the face of DR. FRANKLIN CROWE (70s). He eats the dirt.

Jill spots him and abandons the GUESTS she was greeting.

JILL

Dr. Franklin Crowe! What an honor-
are you eating the dirt?

Crowe looks at Jill and HUFFS.

CROWE

Heavy quartz... low sodium.

JILL

You are brilliant.

CROWE

Much obliged. Thank you a lot.

JILL

May I just say, I read your paper
on disproving the window woman case
in Salem and I was just blown away.

CROWE

I appreciate it. Good luck today.

JILL

You know, I was wondering if you
could have a word with my daughter?
She's been, um, ghost hunting if
you can even believe it and-

CROWE

(MORE)

CROWE (CONT'D)

That's nice. I ghost hunt for a living. Ghost hunting, good.

JILL

Yes, but, but it's not for the sake of disproving them. You see, and-

Crowe taps Jill on the shoulder and walks inside, past a sign with Jill's face on it that reads "NEUROSCIENTIST DR. JILL RAMIREZ ON THE HAUNTING SYMPTOMS OF SCHIZOPHRENIA PODCAST."

CROWE

We'll see. Yes?

He gives a thumbs up and a massive smile. Jill nods, smile cracking.

EXT. HELL HOUSE - NIGHT

A well dressed young man walks towards Dylan through a crowd of strangers greeting one another. Charlotte, Hodge, and Miguel all side hug him. Miguel does a double take.

EXT. HELL HOUSE, SNACK TABLE - NIGHT

Dylan's at the snack table, acting like she's preoccupied with indecision to avoid all the intellects. This young man comes up from behind her with a little wave.

MITCH

Dylan, is it? Dylan Klaypool?

Mouth half full, Dylan turns respectfully before her eyes bulge. This man is Mitch. He's just...normal. Black hair, no makeup, no piercings, no nail polish. Tattoos covered.

MITCH

Well, what do you think?! ...It kinda sucks, right? It sucks. Be honest.

DYLAN

No, no! It doesn't suck, but...

MITCH

What?

DYLAN

(MORE)

DYLAN (CONT'D)
It's just making me realize I've
never really seen your face until
now. You have wrinkles around your
eyes like a little old man.

Mitch smiles, causing his eyes to crinkle.

DYLAN
Ah. That's why.

They stare at each other for a moment.

DYLAN
You're handsome.

A beat because Mitch felt his heart fall into stomach acid.

DYLAN
What? No joke?

MITCH
Would you still have rejected me if
I looked like this when we met?

Dylan BLINKS, taken aback. Jill comes up to them.

JILL
Hello, Dylan. I see you've made a-
She notices Mitch.

JILL
Friend?
Dylan and Mitch smile at her with nervous hope: here we go.

INT. HELL HOUSE, HALLWAY - NIGHT

Jill drags Mitch to a hidden corner, away from her guests.

JILL
What exactly do you think you're
doing here?

MITCH
You invited me.

Jill can't believe this.

MITCH
(MORE)

MITCH (CONT'D)

...I want to apologize for putting Dylan in a dangerous, uncomfortable situation and for any influence I've had over her that contradicted your remarkable parenting.

JILL

Oh really? My remarkable parenting?

It's chaos around them. A WAITER comes up to Jill and whispers in her ear.

JILL

Well what's wrong with the mummies in a blanket?

MITCH

Mummies in a blanket. Ha! That's brilliant. No wonder you have a PHD, Mrs. Kl... amirez.

JILL

(to the waiter)

Can't this wait?

Charlotte rushes in from the living room.

CHARLOTTE

Jill! Projectors down with fifteen minutes to show.

Jill stresses, looks at Mitch.

JILL

You? Just... stay in shadow.

She goes. Mitch walks out of the hallway and into the...

INT. PODCAST LIVING ROOM - NIGHT

The decor is a blend of spooky and elegant. A row of chairs faces a microphone stand and a backdrop where Jill will soon speak before a crowd.

Mitch runs into CARRIE LANDRY.

CARRIE

You went missing.

MITCH

(MORE)

MITCH (CONT'D)

False alarm.

CARRIE

They said you killed yourself.

MITCH

Don't really see a point in that
for someone who believes in the
afterlife so...

They lock eyes, both thinking about the same unspoken story.

MITCH

I'd never.

CARRIE

You promise?

MITCH

...I promise.

Carrie holds out her pinkie. Mitch clutches it with his and seals it with a kiss. Carrie wipes her eyes.

CARRIE

Good. Now... what the fuck have you
done to yourself?

She shakes a hand through his hair.

MITCH

What? This is the real me.

CARRIE

No... Blue hair is the real you.

MITCH

Blue?

Another long look.

MITCH

Where's your new boyfriend?

INT. HELL HOUSE, FOYER - NIGHT

The doors of Hell House open wide and the outside crowd bursts in, led by Parker Hall and Lexie Wilson.

PARKER

(MORE)

PARKER (CONT'D)
HELLOOO, GHOSTS, WHAT THE FUCK IS
GOOD?

INT. PODCAST LIVING ROOM - NIGHT (CONTINUOUS)

Mitch watches Carrie close her eyes in annoyance as Parker and Lexie come in from around the corner.

LEXIE (O.S.)
(laughing)
Parker, stop!

PARKER
(to Carrie)
Hey, hot thing.

Carrie makes a jumping motion as though Parker grabbed her ass. He kisses her, but she pulls away. Her eyes shyly land on Mitch, which is not lost on Parker.

CARRIE
Let's find a seat, OK?

PARKER (O.S.)
A seat? I though we were just gonna
find a room.

As Carrie and Parker leave, Dylan is revealed. She gives Mitch an inquisitive look. Warmth seems to rush over him.

MITCH
You made it in.

DYLAN
All by my self. That's two for two
this week. Two for two and a half.

He takes her hand softly, leading the way upstairs past a do not enter SIGN. Dr. Franklin Crowe catches sight of this and SNICKERS.

INT. HELL HOUSE, UPSTAIRS HALLWAY - NIGHT

Dylan and Mitch arrive upstairs, only lit by runaway lights.

DYLAN
We have an hour.

They hear footsteps and dive into a corner, close together. Mitch looks Dylan up and down jokingly. She pushes his face and tries to catch sight of the person.

It's Lexie. She sends a text before ducking into a bedroom.

They emerge and take the next turn, coming face-to-face with the ominous door at the end of a long hallway.

MITCH
Classic.

The lights below dim and the applause of Jill's crowd fills the house. Mitch walks forward before realizing Dylan hasn't moved. She's performing some sort of inner ritual.

MITCH
(hushed tones)
DYLAN!

Eyes still closed, she raises her hand to shut him up.

DYLAN
I'm preparing.

ANNOUNCER (O.S.)
All right. All right. Thank you.
Let's all collect ourselves.

Soft footsteps from the stairs, followed by shadow. Mitch PICKS Dylan up and RUNS into the nearest room.

INT. SANDRA'S ROOM - NIGHT

Mitch, Dylan draped over his shoulder, shuts the door. They look around to see the 1990S time capsule they're standing in. A teenage girl's pink bedroom, done up with edgy posters. Now falling apart, overcome with dust and cobwebs.

DYLAN
I don't like it in here.

MITCH
Well it is haunted, Dylan. Which is kind of what we're looking for.

Mitch reaches into his bag. He extends the Mel-Meter's antenna and powers it up.

DYLAN
It's more than that.

MITCH
Thirty-one point eight degrees.

Chills run through Dylan. She clutches her necklace.

DYLAN
Mitch.

Mitch nods as in yeah no I totally hear you.

MITCH
What's up, Spirit? My name is
Mitch. Is there anything you'd like
to share?

Dylan spots a photo of a well-dressed family: two parents
and a young girl. The frame says SANDRA.

DYLAN
Sandra...

The temperature readout instantly drops to 21.3 DEGREES.

MITCH
Whoa. Dylan... Dylan, what did you
say just now?

DYLAN
Sandra?

The temperature drops again: 19.8 degree.

MITCH
Holy shit. Say something else.

Dylan shakes her head.

MITCH
Do you want to prove ghosts exist
or not?!

INT. PODCAST LIVING ROOM - NIGHT

Jill speaks into a microphone before the eager crowd.

JILL
That's a great question. Truly. It
gets to the heart of what I do.

She glances over the crowd.

JILL
Let me make one thing clear—
disproving the existence of ghosts
is only a byproduct of this study.
Really, our work is about something
much bigger.

INT. SANDRA'S ROOM - NIGHT

Back in the bedroom, Dylan gives in.

DYLAN
...We know you're innocent.

The Mel-meter lights up and REM Pod SQUEALS. Mitch, at first elated, realizes their predicament.

MITCH
SHIT. The podcast!

DYLAN
Turn it off! Why won't it turn
off?!

MITCH
Something's jammed!

DYLAN
Well, don't hit it!

INT. PODCAST LIVING ROOM - NIGHT

Miguel stiffens at the sound.

JILL
Places like this aren't haunted by
spirits, but by us. Our fears, our
stories, our-

Miguel comes onstage, whispers in Jill's ear. The audience looks around, confused. Dr. Crowe raises an eyebrow, eyes on the stairs. Jill inaudibly responds to Miguel, who nods.

INT. SANDRA'S ROOM - NIGHT

Mitch tosses Dylan the REM Pod like it's a hot potato.

MITCH

You try!

DYLAN

Get that thing away from me!

She tosses it back. He tosses it back.

MITCH

Don't be a baby!

DYLAN

(gasps)

How dare you?

MITCH

DYLAN!

Dylan lifts a pillow to hide the REM Pod and a cloud rises. She sees a swarm of cockroaches under the pillow and SQUEALS, tossing the Mel-Meter. Mitch covers her mouth.

Miguel's footsteps approach from outside the room. They watch his shadow grow longer beneath the door. Mitch motions to the closet and removes his hand. Dylan nods. When Mitch opens the closet, Dylan takes a step back.

DYLAN

No. No, Mitch.

The bedroom knob turns slowly. Mitch tries to pull Dylan in, but she yanks her hand back with a furious look in the eyes.

CUT TO:

INT. HELL HOUSE, TEEN GIRL'S BEDROOM - NIGHT (MOMENTS LATER)

Miguel opens the door. He hears a faint screeching and looks around for its source.

The REM Pod is below some sheets. He picks it up, analyzing with curiosity, then takes out the batteries to silence it. His eyes land on the closet door. Miguel creeps towards it ever so slowly... he opens it.

Nothing. It's entirely empty. Just some old clothes.

INT. HELL HOUSE, ANOTHER HALLWAY - NIGHT

Pitch black. A small space.

DYLAN
Light please. Quickly.

MITCH
My phone's out of battery.

DYLAN
You smoke, don't you?

MITCH
Someone's testy.

Mitch flicks on his lighter that says "wink when you pass this back if you want to bang" and the flame illuminates Dylan's tested expression.

DYLAN
Subtle.

Mitch grins.

MITCH
And effective.

He takes the lead, shedding a light on a small and cobwebbed corridor.

MITCH
What is this, the house's spleen?

DYLAN
I felt it... behind the vanity. A hollow in the wind.

Mitch turns to Dylan, looking at her differently. She stops.

DYLAN
Something's coming... where's the REM Pod?

Mitch gives Dylan a screwed look. Dylan takes a deep breath. Eyes shut, she suddenly grabs for her chest.

MITCH
Dylan?! Dylan, say something!

The flame flickers with gusts of wind. Mitch grabs Dylan's hand. Her eyes shoot open with a gasp.

DYLAN
I heard blood. I feel an evil, but the energy to it, it's different. They're telling me... to run.

MITCH
(MORE)

MITCH (CONT'D)
...THEY'RE?!

The flame goes out, leaving them in the dark. Downstairs,
the audience starts screaming in terror.

MITCH
What the hell is happening?!

DYLAN
I told you!

Dylan and Mitch break through a small door and tumble over
one another into...

INT. HELL HOUSE, MASTER BEDROOM - NIGHT (CONTINUOUS)

The master bedroom of Hell House. To her and Mitch's
absolute horror, blood is running down the walls.

DYLAN
Blood.

They hear a scream inside their same room and look over to
find Lexie Wilson, holding covers over her bare body. She is
followed by none other than Parker Hall. He sees the blood.

PARKER
WHAT THE FUC-
END OF EPISODE

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Episode 103

"The Ghost Next Door"

Written by

Taylor Castro

Based on

"The Haunting of Dylan Klaypool: Whispers in Black Willow"

by James A. Ross